The pistol ladder and how to self-assess

Mission: 3 clean, unassisted pistols on each leg. Today: level 1 (assisted, shaky).

> **Today's win:** on your next tower visit, hold the upright and do 3 slow assisted pistols per leg, then 1 minute of the ankle drill. That's the whole plan in miniature.

What counts as a clean pistol

1. **Stand** on one leg, the other leg straight out in front, foot off the floor.[1]
2. **Down** under control (about 3 seconds), knee tracking over your toes, heel down, as low as you can.[1]
3. **Up** to a straight knee. Free foot never touches down. Some forward lean and rounding at the bottom is normal.[1]

The bottom is the hardest part, not the descent[2], which matches what you feel. Your three limiters: **bottom strength**, **ankle mobility** (the big forward lean), and **free-leg control/balance**.

The ladder

Practitioners converge on supported pistols with less and less help, box pistols at falling height, then a counterweight.[3][1]

Level	Variation	How
1	Assisted pistol	Both hands on the tower upright, full depth, pull only as much as you need.
2	Light-assist pistol	One hand or fingertips; help only at the very bottom.
3	High box pistol	Sit to a bench about knee height, pause, stand without rocking.
4	Low box pistol	Same, lowering the box a notch (a book or cushion) each time you pass.
5	Counterweight pistol	Full depth holding a light dumbbell out in front at arm's length; it shifts balance forward and eases the ankle demand.[4]
6	Free pistol	The goal: 3 clean reps per leg.

You can work two rungs side by side (say level 2 and level 3); log the highest you pass.

How to self-assess

- **Pass a rung**: 3 clean reps per leg on 2 separate days. Then move up.
- **Not clean**: heel lifts, knee caves in, free foot touches, or you bounce/rock up. Stay put.
- **Use the weaker leg** to set the level for both.
- **Diagnose the lean**: if heels lift in a deep two-leg squat, it's ankles; do the drill.[2]

Your daily dose (weekdays)

WHAT	DOSE
Pistol sets	2–3 tower visits: 3 reps per leg at your level, fresh, never to failure.[5]
Ankle drill	Once a day: half-kneeling, pulse the front knee forward over the toes 10 times with the heel down, then hold 20 s. Each side.[2]
Free-leg hold	Once a day: stand on one leg, other leg straight out front, 10–15 s each side (lightly touch the upright if needed).
Wed Oct 28	**Check-in test** with pull-ups and dips: warm up, then find the highest level (or lowest box) with 3 clean reps per leg.

Any knee pain: drop a level. Missed a day? Don't make it up.

Log today

Text Gopher your level and reps per leg. They get added to the progress log.

Check yourself

1. You hit 3 clean high-box reps per leg on two separate days. What now?

- add more reps per set
- lower the box a notch
- try a free pistol now

2. Your heels lift in a deep two-leg squat. What is the likely limiter?

- weak hip flexor power
- hamstring flexibility
- limited ankle bending

3. Left leg passes level 3, right does not. Which level do you train?

- level 3 on both legs
- level 4 on both legs
- left at 4, right at 3

4. Your free foot brushes the floor at the bottom. How do you count it?

- count it as half-rep
- count it as clean rep
- not clean, stay there

Read this

Primary source: ExRx: Single Leg Squat (pistol), with video and its easier/harder versions. Then GMB's pistol progression for the ankle drill.

Anything unclear? **Ask your teacher.** Message me in chat, text your level each day, and send your test result on Oct 28.

Sources: [1] ExRx.net, Single Leg Squat (pistol). [2] GMB Fitness, Pistol Squat Progression. [3][4] r/bodyweightfitness threads on pistol progressions. [5] Tsatsouline, "Grease the Groove for Strength" (reprint).